Galatians 2

One gospel, one table · Standing firm together

LAST SESSION REVIEW

In Galatians 1, Paul opened with the gospel as rescue: Jesus "gave himself for our sins to rescue us" (1:4). Adding any requirement to his work turns it into a different gospel (1:6–9). Paul's own story showed why. His zeal and achievement were aimed against the church until God called him by grace (1:13–16). The gospel came from Christ, not from human approval.

SCRIPTURE

Open your Bibles to **Galatians 2:1–21**. Galatians is a letter: Paul is making a case to churches he loves, so follow his reasoning. Chapter 2 tells two scenes, a meeting in Jerusalem (2:1–10) and a confrontation over a meal in Antioch (2:11–14), then explains what was at stake (2:15–21). Watch for *freedom*, *the truth of the gospel*, and *justified*.

Part 1 · Freedom Confirmed

Galatians 2:1–10

Fourteen years later, Paul goes to Jerusalem with Barnabas and Titus, a Gentile believer. He lays his gospel before the church's leaders. Titus is not compelled to be circumcised: Gentiles belong to Christ without first becoming Jewish. Some slipped in to spy on the freedom believers have in Christ, but Paul did not give way, so that the truth of the gospel would be preserved. James, Peter, and John give him the right hand of fellowship. It is one gospel with different callings, and they ask only that he remember the poor, which he was eager to do. Paul stood firm, yet he let other leaders examine his message. Conviction and accountability belong together.

DISCUSS

1. What was at stake when Titus was not compelled to be circumcised (2:3–5)? What does it tell us about who belongs to Christ?
2. Paul held firm, yet he laid his gospel before other leaders (2:2). Where do you need both: conviction to stand on the gospel, and humility to let brothers speak into your life?

Part 2 · Living in Step with the Gospel

Galatians 2:11–21

In Antioch, Peter ate with Gentile believers until certain men came from James. Then he withdrew, “because he feared those from the circumcision party” (2:12), and others followed, even Barnabas. Peter announced no new teaching. He changed his table, and his conduct denied the gospel he believed. So Paul opposed him to his face, in front of everyone.

Then Paul explains what was at stake. A person is justified, declared right with God, not by works of the law but by faith in Jesus Christ (2:16). The Christian life is not self-improvement on a better foundation. It is union with Christ: “I have been crucified with Christ, and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me” (2:20). If righteousness came through the law, Christ died for nothing (2:21).

Peter was a bold man, and fear of the right crowd still moved him. Brothers who love one another tell the truth, and receive it.

DISCUSS

1. Peter didn’t change his words; he changed his table. How can our actions deny the gospel even when our beliefs are right?
2. Read 2:20 slowly. What changes when your identity rests on “Christ lives in me” rather than your record, your reputation, or the approval of the men you respect?

REFLECTIONS

1. Where does fear of what others think shape where you “sit”: whom you stand with, speak up for, or avoid?
2. Is there a brother you need to speak truth to in love this week, or receive it from?

CLOSE PRAYER

Lord Jesus, you loved us and gave yourself for us. Thank you that we are justified by faith in you, not by our record. Forgive us where fear of others has moved us out of step with your gospel. By your Spirit, make us brothers who stand firm, tell the truth in love, receive correction, and welcome one another at your table. Christ, live in us. Amen.

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